How to run a debate

Primary: Mainly Years 5 and 6. Two schools, one motion, 30 minutes. Everything you need to run the debate, from setting up the room to the final vote.

DEBATE TIME	AGE GROUP	CLASS SIZE	WHERE	JUDGED ON
30 minutes	**Primary**	**About 30**	**In person or online**	**Argument, Evidence, Rebuttal, Delivery**

Two to three weeks before

1. **Agree the fixture.** On the debate page: the date, in person or online, the theme, the motion and a judge. Tell your pupils which side your school argues.
2. **Survey your own pupils.** A class vote or tally chart, with the teacher helping. Ask the same few questions in every class that takes part. Use the same questions as the other school, from your prep pack, so the results can be compared on the day. Do not record names.
3. **Research in three groups.** Work from short fact cards, one fact to a card.
   - **The facts:** What is actually true, and how do we know?
   - **The people affected:** Who gains, who loses, and who is not in the room?
   - **Rules and responsibilities:** Who decides, who is accountable, and what should the rules be?
4. **Check every fact twice.** Use more than one source for each fact, and write down where it came from. Never rely on AI-generated content alone: it can be wrong and still sound certain.
5. **Name your roles** (see Who does what).
6. **Prepare the speeches.** Start with a 60-second brainstorm of everything that comes to mind, then pick one central idea that every point leads back to. List the arguments you expect from the other side. Plan each speech as an opening line that hooks the room, two or three points with evidence, and a strong last line.
7. **Notes.** Speakers can write their speech on a card in big letters and read from it.

8. **Warm up in lessons.** Short games, one for each part of speaking well:
    - **Say it with feeling** (voice): say an ordinary sentence as if angry, excited or worried, and the group guesses the feeling.
    - **Don't say the word** (words): describe a word on a card, such as "privacy", without saying it.
    - **Because, but, so** (reasons): round the circle, each person adds to a claim with "because", "but" or "so".
    - **Say it back** (listening): before giving a view, sum up what the last speaker said, until they agree you have it right.
9. **Rehearse in debate conditions:** standing up, against the timer, with someone asking questions or interrupting.
10. **Practise.** Practise the corner vote in a lesson beforehand, so pupils know where to go.

What you need

For every debate

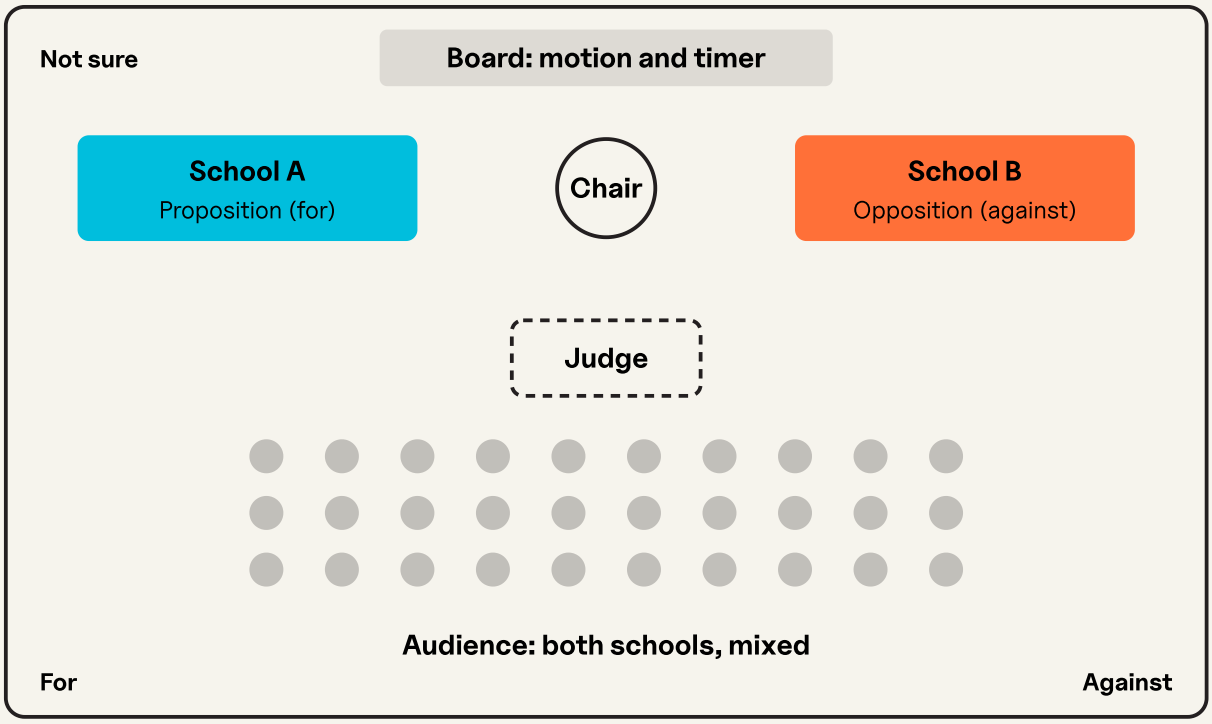
- ☐ The motion on the board, where everyone can read it
- ☐ A timer everyone can see, on the board or a large screen
- ☐ Timing cards for the chair: 30 seconds and Stop, held up with each knock (see On the day)
- ☐ A rebuttal card for each team, printed from this guide
- ☐ Two tables at the front, facing the audience, with chairs for each team
- ☐ Each school's survey chart: one slide or one printed sheet
- ☐ Note-taking sheets and pens for the note-takers and the audience
- ☐ The judge's scorecard: on their phone, or printed from the debate page in case the Wi-Fi fails

For primary

- ☐ Three corner signs: For, Against and Not sure
- ☐ The sentence starter on display: "I think __ because __."
- ☐ Fact cards, one fact to a card
- ☐ Sticky notes, for pupils to write floor questions on

Online? You also need a camera, a room microphone and a projector: see If you debate online.

Set up the room



The room from above. School A, the Proposition, argues for; School B, the Opposition, argues against.

1. **Front of the room:** School A's table on one side and School B's on the other, both facing the audience. Speakers stand to speak.
2. **The chair** sits between the two tables, with the timer on the board behind them.
3. **The judge** sits facing the front, where they can see and hear both teams, slightly apart from the audience.
4. **The audience** sits in rows or a horseshoe, mixed between the schools, with a clear path for questioners to stand.
5. **Corner signs:** put For, Against and Not sure in three corners, with room for a third of the class in each.
6. **Check before anyone arrives:** the motion and the timer are on the board, and the survey charts are ready to show.

Who does what

For a class of about 30. Each school names six roles. Everyone else is a note-taker or a questioner, so the whole room has a job.

ROLE	WHAT THEY DO
Chair (1, agreed between the schools)	Introduces the motion and the rules, keeps time, takes the floor questions and announces the votes. Often a teacher at primary; a student can chair at secondary and post-16.
Judge (1)	Invited by the host school. Scores each school from 1 to 5 on argument, evidence, rebuttal, delivery, and submits the official result.
Survey presenters (2)	Share the school's survey findings at the start.
Opening speaker (1)	Makes the school's case.
Rebuttal speaker (1)	Answers what the other side said, using the notes.
Closing speaker (1)	Sums up in the school's last minute.
Lead note-taker (1)	Listens to the other side and briefs the rebuttal speaker.
Note-takers	Listen to the other side's opening case, and feed the rebuttal in the huddle.
Questioners	Ask the floor questions to either side.

> **Teacher tip.** Give every pupil a job card with their role on it. Speakers can read from a card; questioners write their question on a sticky note first.

Keeping order. The chair keeps order with the quiet signal: for talking during a speech, interrupting, or anything unkind. The judge says nothing during the debate: they listen, take notes and score.

On the day, step by step

The first 10 minutes set the scene; the rest is the debate. The time beside each step is minutes from the start. Where a stage says “each”, each school has that long in turn.

Timing signals

One knock	30 seconds left. Hold up the 30 seconds card.
Two knocks	Time is up: finish the sentence. Hold up Stop.
Knocking that keeps going	From 15 seconds over, until the speaker sits down.

Practise the knocks in a lesson first, so nobody is startled.

1 0:00

Welcome and roles 3 min

The chair introduces the motion and the rules, and confirms who is speaking, taking notes and asking questions.

Pupils: Speakers sit at their school's table; everyone else sits in the audience.

> **Teacher tip.** Point to the sentence starter on the board, and agree a quiet signal, such as a raised hand.

2 3:00

Opening vote 3 min

The room votes for, against or undecided by moving to a corner of the room. The result is recorded.

Pupils: Pupils walk to the For, Against or Not sure corner, then tell a talk partner why they chose it.

> **Teacher tip.** Count each corner and write the numbers on the board, then everyone sits back down.

3 6:00

Survey findings 2 min each

Each school shares what its own students said: a simple chart and one key finding.

Pupils: The two survey presenters from each school share their chart and one key finding.

> **Teacher tip.** One chart is plenty. Keep it to what their own students said, not what they think.

4 10:00

Opening cases 2 min each

Proposition, then Opposition. The other side takes notes.

Pupils: The opening speaker makes the case. Note-takers on the other side write down every point to answer.

> **Teacher tip.** Speakers can read from their card. Stand beside a nervous speaker if it helps.

5 14:00

Rebuttal preparation 3 min

Each team huddles with its note-takers, while the audience talks in pairs.

Pupils: The note-takers tell the rebuttal speaker which points to answer. In the audience, pairs talk about the strongest point so far.

> **Teacher tip.** The lead note-taker briefs the rebuttal speaker. Keep the timer running on the board.

6 17:00

Rebuttal 1 min each

Opposition goes first, then Proposition.

Pupils: The rebuttal speaker answers what the other side actually said, using the notes.

> **Teacher tip.** A rebuttal is not a second speech. Listen for “They said… but…”.

7 19:00

Floor questions 4 min

The chair takes questions from the audience, to either side.

Pupils: Questioners ask a question to either side; any speaker may answer. Nobody questions their own school's team.

> **Teacher tip.** Pick questions from the sticky notes pupils wrote during the opening cases.

8 23:00

Closing 1 min each

Opposition first, Proposition last.

Pupils: The closing speaker sums up why their side should win the vote.

> **Teacher tip.** No new arguments in the closing speech: pick the two or three biggest disagreements of the debate and show why your side won them.

9 25:00

Changeover buffer 2 min

Covers any overrun.

> **Teacher tip.** Use it to catch up if a stage ran over. If you are on time, give it to floor questions.

10 27:00

Final vote and result 3 min

The room votes again, and the chair announces the swing: who changed their minds.

Pupils: Pupils go back to a corner. Who moved? Ask one or two pupils what changed their mind.

> **Teacher tip.** The vote shows who persuaded the room; the judge's scorecard is the official result.

Rebuttal card

Rebuttal answers what the other side actually said. Take on their strongest argument, even if your answer is not perfect: ignoring it is worse.

REBUTTAL CARD: PRIMARY

I disagree because...
Say which point you are answering, then give your reason.

That is not always true. For example...
Give one example that shows the point does not always work.

But what about...?
Name someone or something the other side forgot.

What a good speech sounds like

Four questions for pupils to ask themselves, one for each part of speaking well. Put them on the board while speakers practise, and use them for feedback.

PART	ASK YOURSELF
Voice and body	Can everyone hear me? Am I changing my voice and looking at the audience to make my point?
Words	Am I choosing words my audience understands, and strong words that persuade?
Reasons	Is my point clear, and have I given a reason and an example?
Listening	Did I listen to the other side, and answer what they really said?

After the Voice 21 Oracy Framework: physical, linguistic, cognitive, and social and emotional.

How debating grows, Key Stage 2 to 5

Each stage builds on the one before. Your pupils' stage is highlighted; move a confident group on to the next column.

	KS2	KS3	KS4	KS5
Notes	Read from a card	Prompt cards	Headings only	Headings only, no script
Rebuttal	"I disagree because…"	Not true, doesn't follow, doesn't matter	Adds contradictions	The full list, and counter-rebuttal
Interruptions	None	None	Points of information, optional	Points of information, with protected time
Floor questions	Written on sticky notes first	Asked live, answered straight away	Asked live, or answered in closing	Answered in the closing speeches
Feedback	Four "ask yourself" questions	ESU four skill sets	ESU four skill sets	ESU four skill sets

Keeping it fair

- [ ] Sides are given, not chosen. Tell pupils it is fine to argue a side they disagree with: that is the skill.
- [ ] Both sides get the same time and the same chance to answer.
- [ ] The chair and teachers stay neutral, and keep their own views on the motion to themselves.
- [ ] Some AI motions touch on political questions, such as who should make the rules. The debate format gives pupils at least two genuinely different views, which is what the DfE asks for.
- [ ] The judge is a visitor: follow your school's usual visitor and safeguarding checks, and a teacher stays in the room.
- [ ] Challenge the argument, never the person. Personal remarks are stopped by the chair.

See the DfE's Political impartiality in schools (updated March 2025), in Further reading.

Including every student

- ☐ Every role counts. Note-takers, questioners and survey presenters shape the debate as much as the speakers.
- ☐ Speakers may read from a card, share a speech between two, or use sign language or a communication aid. Oracy includes all of these.
- ☐ If a student stammers, give them time and never finish their sentences. Brief the judge: a stammer is never marked down under Delivery.
- ☐ Use the cards and the knocks together, so every student can see or hear the time.
- ☐ Give the motion and the questions early to anyone who needs more time to think, and keep sentence starters on display.
- ☐ Give students learning English a short list of key words for the motion, and let them prepare with a partner.
- ☐ Plan adjustments with your SENCO, as you would for any lesson.

After the debate

1. **The judge submits the scorecard** on their phone, or enters the paper one later. Their submission is the official result, and both schools see it on the debate page.
2. **Ask your pupils again.** Run the survey after the debate with a class PIN, to see whether views changed.
3. **Talk about it.** What was the strongest argument on the other side? Did anything change your mind?
4. **Be recognised.** Taking part is recorded straight away. Two debates against two different schools earns the National AI Debate School certificate.

If you debate online

The host school, School A, sets up the meeting on its own platform and adds the link to the debate page. The link is then on the debate page and in both calendar entries.

Equipment

- [ ] One computer in each room, with a camera that shows the speakers
- [ ] A room microphone or speakerphone, so the whole team can be heard
- [ ] A projector and speakers, so the room sees and hears the other school
- [ ] The timer shared on screen by the chair, so both rooms see it

Running it

- [ ] Test the link, sound and camera together 15 minutes before
- [ ] The host admits everyone from the waiting room and controls who joins
- [ ] Nobody records the debate, and the chat stays off
- [ ] Speakers come to the camera to speak; mute the room when it is not your turn
- [ ] Votes: hands up to the camera, counted in each room, or a poll in the meeting
- [ ] The judge joins the meeting and scores on their phone

> **Teacher tip.** Corner votes still work online: each room counts its own corners and the chair adds the two together.

Curriculum links

English, spoken language, Years 1 to 6 (statutory). Pupils should be taught to "participate in discussions, presentations, performances, role play, improvisations and debates", to "articulate and justify answers, arguments and opinions", and to "consider and evaluate different viewpoints, attending to and building on the contributions of others".

English, reading, Years 5 and 6. Pupils explain their understanding "through formal presentations and debates, maintaining a focus on the topic and using notes where necessary", and "provide reasoned justifications for their views".

Oracy is growing in importance: the Curriculum and Assessment Review (November 2025) recommended a national oracy framework, and new primary and secondary frameworks are planned to go with the revised national curriculum from September 2028.

Further reading

- DfE: National curriculum in England, English programmes of study
  https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/national-curriculum-in-england-english-programmes-of-study
- DfE: Citizenship programmes of study, Key Stages 3 and 4
  https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/national-curriculum-in-england-citizenship-programmes-of-study
- DfE: Political impartiality in schools
  https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/political-impartiality-in-schools
- Awarding bodies: Spoken Language Endorsement for GCSE English Language (AQA)
  https://filestore.aqa.org.uk/resources/english/AQA-8700-SL-ENDORSEMENT.PDF
- English-Speaking Union: Schools' Mace handbook
  https://www.esu.org/competitions/schools-mace/
- Voice 21: The Oracy Framework
  https://voice21.org/
- Oak National Academy: Participating in effective debates (Key Stage 3)
  https://www.thenational.academy/teachers/programmes/english-secondary-ks3/units/participating-in-effective-debates/lessons

The running order is recommended, not compulsory: change the stages or timings to suit your pupils. The format is a draft and will be reviewed by debate educators before national use.